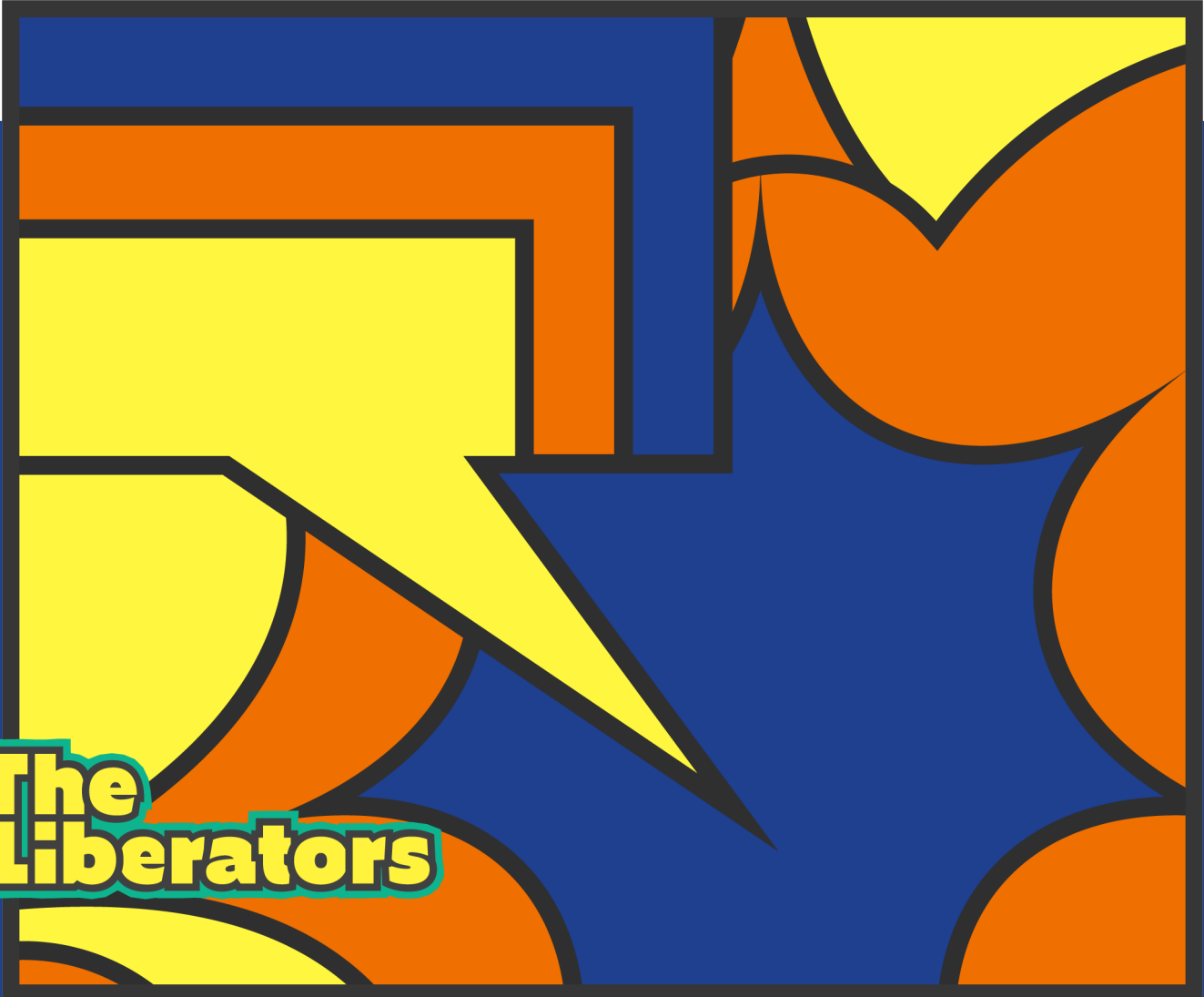


Invite Deep Learning Into Your Sprint Retrospectives

A do-it-yourself workshop to improve the quality of the Sprint Retrospective and turn it into an engine for continuous improvement



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

Doing Scrum well is hard. But you know that. This means that continuous learning and improvement are necessary to overcome those pesky impediments that keep popping up. It also requires a lot of creativity and outside-of-the-box thinking.

One way to think of the Scrum framework is to understand it as a framework for continuous improvement. Every Sprint brings with it a new opportunity to experiment with potential improvements. Some will work and some won't. Teams that don't leverage these learning opportunities, inevitably wither away into Zombie Scrum.

One excellent moment for such learning to take place, but certainly not the only one, is the Sprint

Retrospective. At least once per Sprint, the Scrum team takes a moment to reflect on how to improve their process, their technology, and their collaboration with stakeholders. It's an opportunity to improve the Definition of Done and to figure out how to make the next Sprint more enjoyable.

But for many Scrum teams, the Sprint Retrospective doesn't feel like an important learning opportunity at all. Conversations remain superficial, the "elephant in the room" is never really addressed and the same improvements keep being raised – without actually implementing them. In those circumstances, it is no surprise when Scrum teams prefer to skip them.

We designed this short 60-minute workshop to get out of this rut. Essentially, we ask your team to reflect on the effectiveness of the Sprint Retrospective and learning in your team in general.

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by These Robots for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Veege, Johannes Schellekens & Barry Christiaan



Flow



Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Clarify The Purpose Of The Sprint Retrospective With Impromptu Networking

  20 min

Step 3: Decide What To Stop Doing With TRIZ

  35 min

Step 4: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 60 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



The structures in the workshop are easy to facilitate. Just don't spoil the twist in TRIZ.

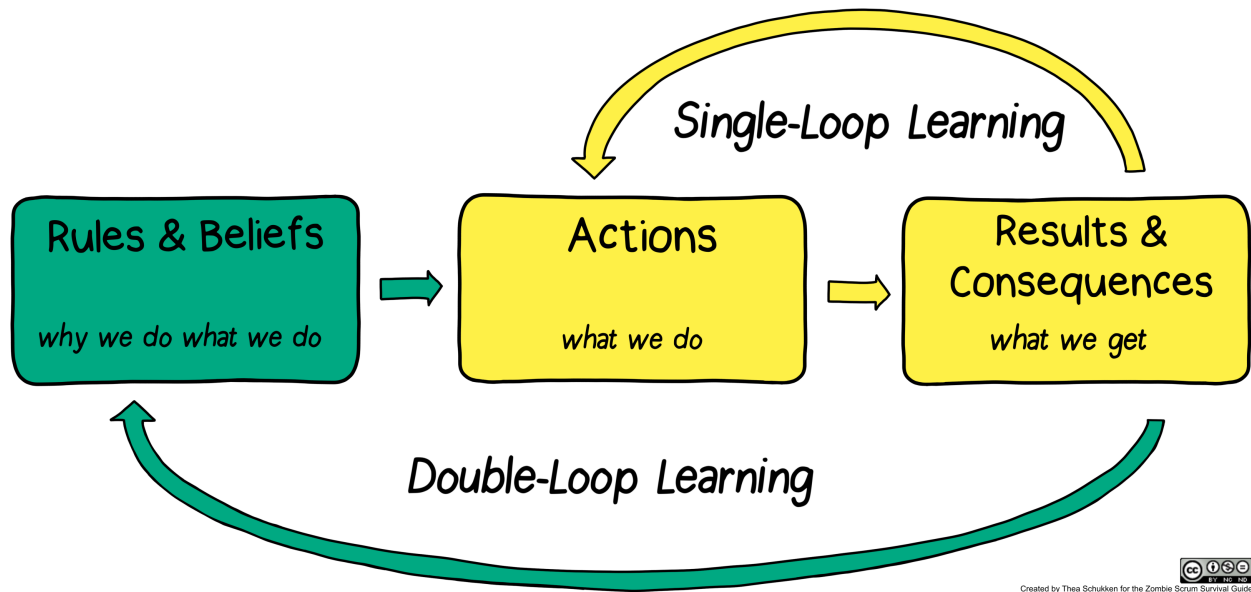
Impact On Survival



The Sprint Retrospective provides important fuel for the continuous improvement-loop of your team and helps you fight Zombie Scrum.



Improve How You Learn As A Team



Source: Argyris, C. On Organizational Learning, Cambridge, MA: Blackwell, 1993

Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijns, Johannes Schertau & Barry Overseem
zombiescrum.org

The [Scrum Guide](#) describes the purpose of the Sprint Retrospective to plan ways to increase quality and effectiveness. The purpose could also be described as a way to learn and reflect. Reflect on how to improve collaboration, the Definition of Done, or how the Sprint events are conducted. Or to learn from experiments you've tried with limiting work-in-progress, pair programming, and test-automation.

On Organizational Learning

When teams don't get value anymore from their Sprint Retrospectives, this could be because of how they learn. While it's essential, teams and organizations are not always aware of how learning takes place. In our book the [Zombie Scrum Survival Guide](#), we included the concept of single- and double-loop learning. It's based on the book [On Organizational Learning](#) by Chris Argyris. In this book, he defines organizational learning as a type of error-detection. Learning requires both the detection of an error as well as the implementation of a solution for it.

Two Types Of Errors

The Scrum framework is essentially a mechanism for detecting two types of errors. The first type are errors that the Scrum Team detects in the product they are developing. The second type are gaps between what would be necessary to detect those errors earlier, and what is actually done to detect them. These are the impediments that teams identify towards working (more) empirically. Focusing on these two types of errors allows teams and organizations to learn in two complementary ways: single-loop learning for errors of the first type, and double-loop learning for errors of the second type.



Single- And Double-Loop Learning

Single-loop learning focuses on solving a problem within an existing system that is defined by sets of beliefs, structures, roles, procedures, and norms. Double-loop learning challenges the system itself. As an example of single-loop learning, a Scrum Team might explore different techniques for estimating their Product Backlog for the purpose of forecasting. The Scrum Team might also use double-loop learning to challenge the purpose of forecasting itself and look for other ways to satisfy the need to forecast. Another example of single-loop learning is when developers try to fix broken unit tests faster, whereas double-loop learning would see them question why their unit tests are so prone to breaking in the first place. A final example of single-loop learning is when a Product Owner tries to better capture requirements on the Product Backlog, whereas double-loop learning might make her question the need for detailed requirements in an empirical process in the first place.

So where single-loop learning improves what is possible within the current system, double-loop learning is about challenging and changing the system. Double-loop learning helps people change (sometimes deeply held) assumptions and beliefs.

Why Organizations Struggle

Although both types of learning are important for continuous improvement to happen, Argyris emphasizes double-loop learning as particularly important for non-routine, complex work where teams have to constantly challenge not only how they do the work, but also why. The many changes that organizations have to go through to transition from plan-based approaches to empirical ways of working mean that organizations need to employ a high degree of double-loop learning to change underlying beliefs about risk, control, management, and professionalism.

Organizations that find themselves unable to change the rules, norms, and beliefs that stand in their way will struggle to stay competitive. Unfortunately, Argyris also notes that highly-trained professionals in particular often struggle to practice double-loop learning, as it involves challenging the practices and skills that have made them successful in the past.

The Sprint Retrospective

Fortunately, using the Scrum framework purposefully helps teams leverage both types of learning by creating transparency around how work is done, and by creating opportunities for inspection and adaptation. Although all Scrum events help teams to learn by inspecting and adapting, the Sprint Retrospective is the one that most directly reflects on how work is done. The benefits of this reflection are limited when it focuses only on finding new practices and techniques (single-loop) and doesn't involve challenging underlying beliefs and rules (double-loop).

Teams affected by Zombie Scrum tend to limit themselves to single-loop learning and can't benefit from double-loop learning because their existing beliefs about management, products, how to manage people, and how to control risk remain unchallenged.

Invite Deep Learning Into Your Sprint Retrospectives

If your Sprint Retrospectives remain shallow and only engage your team in single-loop learning, your situation won't improve. We've found it helpful to frequently reflect with teams on *how* they learn. That may sound super abstract, but you'll discover one way to do this with this workshop. This kind of learning makes it more likely for teams to engage in double-loop learning (or even beyond).



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward.

Intended Audience

We designed this workshop for one Scrum team that wants to improve their Retrospective. But the steps also work really well with more Scrum teams. This might help to spot patterns and resolve deeper impediments that prevent continuous improvement.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.

Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Blog post: [Myth: In Scrum, we spend too much time in meetings](#)
- Blog post: [A Retrospective with Liberating Structures at a rapidly growing startup](#)
- Podcast: [Why Scrum Teams Struggle To Improve Continuously](#)



3 min

Step 1: Opening



Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.





Step 2: Clarify The Purpose Of The Sprint Retrospective With Impromptu Networking

The start of this workshop is intended to create a shared understanding of the purpose of the Sprint Retrospective. Especially if the improvement loop in your team has been stuck for a while, it is good to refresh how your Sprint Retrospective can help you get out of this rut.

The Liberating Structure [Impromptu Networking](#) is a great way to quickly let everyone share their ideas and thoughts. The goal isn't to get a fluent purpose statement, it's intended to get everyone's thinking started about the Sprint Retrospective itself, and what they want to achieve with it.



Invitation

"What is important to you about the Sprint Retrospective, and doing them frequently? What should go in, and come out of it?"

Steps

1. **1 min** First offer the invitation and give everyone a minute to silently get their thinking started about what comes to mind when thinking about the purpose of the Sprint Retrospective.
2. **3 min** Ask everyone to form pairs and let them share their ideas and thoughts with their partner. If you're doing this virtually, assign people to breakout rooms.
3. **6 min** Repeat the previous round twice more. Invite people into new pairs, and let them share their thoughts and observations while noticing patterns.
4. **10 min** When everyone is back together, ask the participants for the patterns they noticed. Capture them on a shared surface if you want to.

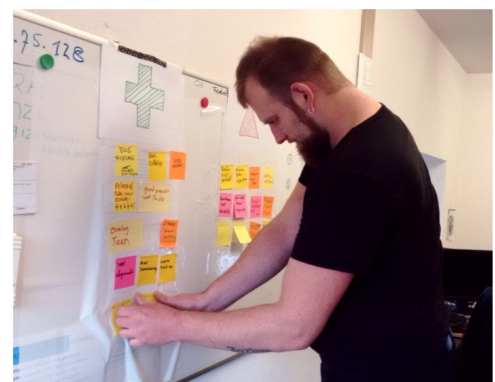
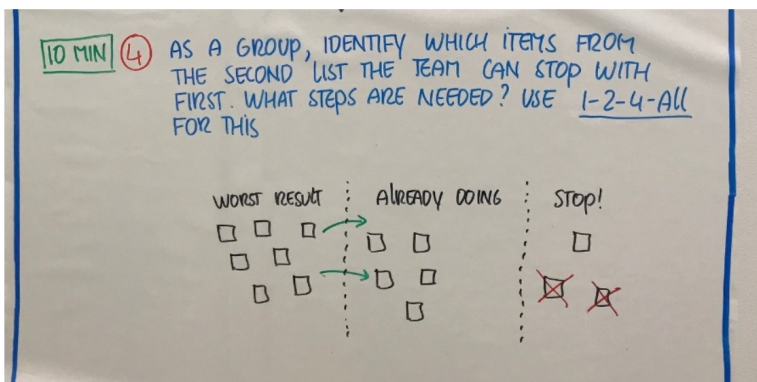
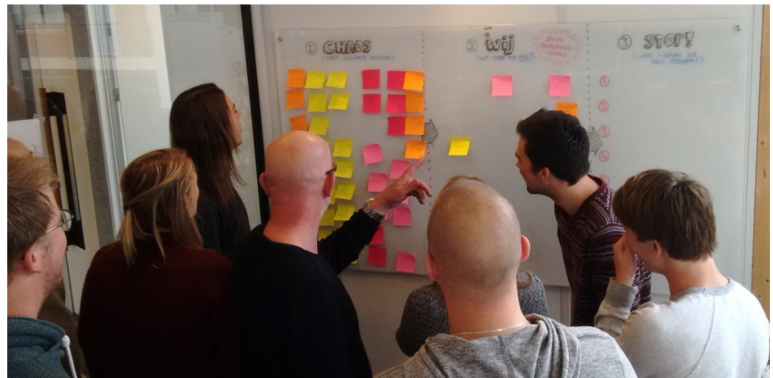
Our Findings

- The purpose of the Sprint Retrospective is to plan ways to increase quality and effectiveness. Although it's fine if the team used different terms, it should be along this line. If needed, refresh the purpose together.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Rapidly share novel ideas and make personal connections with 'Impromptu Networking'](#)

Step 3: Decide What To Stop Doing With TRIZ



Now that you've captured all the ideas everyone has about the purpose of the Sprint Retrospective, it's time to move to the next step which is all about using your imagination. In this step, we use the Liberating Structure [TRIZ](#) to invite participants to have serious fun with a provocative question. It helps create a safe environment where people can be honest. It encourages your team to turn the question on its head; what is the worst possible Retrospective we can have? But then comes the 'twist' in round 2 (don't spoil it).

Invitation

"In your wildest imagination, what would the worst possible Sprint Retrospective look like? What would you see, hear, and notice? What would make it feel like a complete waste of time to everyone involved, and actively push you downhill into deep Zombie Scrum?"

Steps

- **2 min** First individually and in silence, ask everyone to compile a list of all the things they can do, individually or as a team, to guarantee the worst possible outcome.
- **5 min** Invite people into pairs and into separate breakouts. Ask everyone to share their lists and expand them together. Encourage people to go wild here; more is better! Even seemingly ridiculous ideas can lead to great insights.
- **3 min** When everyone is back together, or in the main channel, ask: "In silence, go through your list and mark the items that resemble, or are similar to, something we already do during our Sprint Retrospective."
- **5 min** Invite people into new pairs and move them into separate breakouts. Ask the people to share what they recognized in their pairs.

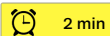
- **3 min** When everyone is back together, or in the main channel, ask: "Based on the items that you recognized in this team, what should we stop doing?"
- **5 min** Invite people into new pairs and move them into separate breakouts. Here, people can share what they think the team must stop doing during their Sprint Retrospective.
- **5 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, ask everyone to capture their biggest takeaways on a shared workspace. Ask the group what patterns they notice. What seems to be something everyone clearly wants to stop with?
- **5 min** From the items everyone expressed the desire to stop with, decide together what first steps will help to do so. Make sure these steps are specific and actionable. If needed, use the Liberating Structure [15% Solutions](#) to define personal next steps.

Our Findings

- Don't spoil the twist in TRIZ between the first and second rounds. Doing so will limit creativity and the brutal honesty that makes TRIZ work, as people will already start reflecting on their current situation during the first round.

Resources

- Blog post: [Stop counterproductive activities and behaviors to make space for innovation with TRIZ](#)
- Blog post: The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website



2 min

Step 4: Closing

With this workshop, you helped the team improve the quality of the Sprint Retrospective so it can become the engine for continuous improvement, once more.

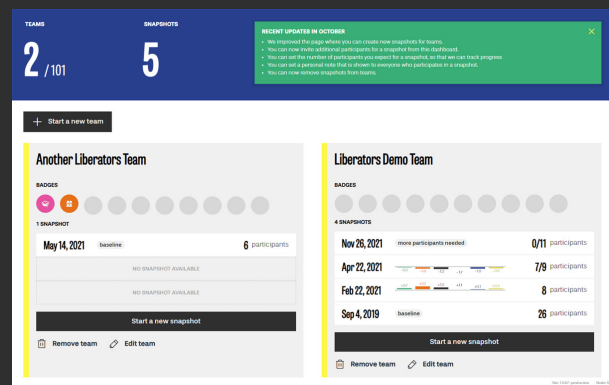
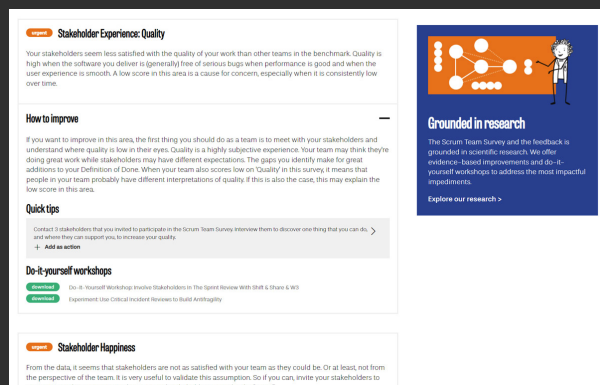
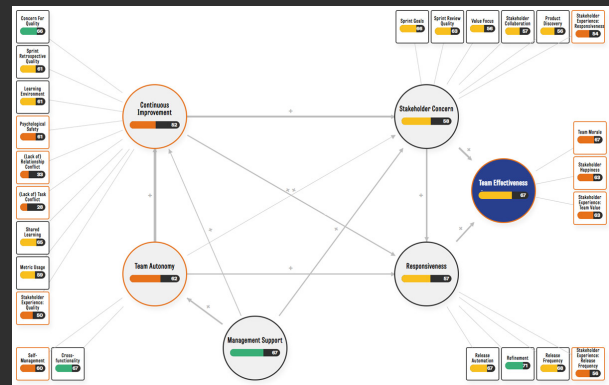
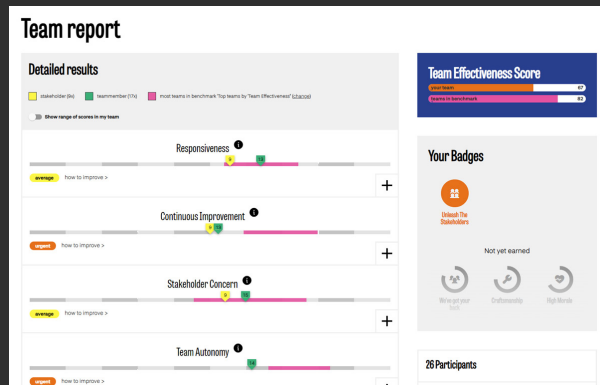
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



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Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

info@scrumteamsurvey.org

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